Despite its French name, this silky-smooth, cold soup actually comes from the US. It is also delicious served hot—simply add the cream and chives at the end of cooking.

vichyssoise

SERVES 4 **PREP** 15 MINS, PLUS 3 HRS CHILLING **COOK** 45 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS BEFORE THE CREAM IS ADDED

CHILLED

2 tbsp butter
3 large leeks (white parts only), finely sliced
2 potatoes, about 6oz (175g) in total, chopped
1 celery rib, coarsely chopped
4 cups hot vegetable stock
salt and freshly ground black pepper
5fl oz (150ml) heavy cream, plus extra to garnish
2 tbsp finely chopped chives

1 Melt the butter in a heavy pan over medium heat, add the leeks, and stir to coat well. Press a circle of damp wax paper on top of them, cover with a lid, and cook, shaking the pan gently from time to time, for 15 minutes or until they are soft and golden. Discard the wax paper.

2 Stir in the potatoes, celery, and stock, then season with salt and freshly ground black pepper. Bring to a boil, stirring all the time, then cover with a lid and simmer for 30 minutes or until the vegetables are tender.

3 Remove the pan from the heat and leave to cool slightly, then process the soup in a blender until very smooth. You may need to do this in batches. Season to taste with salt and freshly ground black pepper, then chill for at least 3 hours. To serve, pour into bowls, stir a little cream into each, then sprinkle with the chives and more freshly ground black pepper.

CHOOSING LEEKS
Although it means trimming and cleaning them, go for leeks with roots and plenty of green leaves rather than the neat cylinders you see in pre-prepared packs—it's hard to tell how fresh these are. For more information, see p23.

